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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

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Research Topic: Sexual Health Knowledge and STI Prevention Behaviors in Myanmar Youth

Sexual Health Knowledge and STI Prevention Behaviors in Myanmar Youth

Abstract

Sexually Transmitted Infections (STIs) are an important public health issue amongst young people. This study aims to investigate the association between sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors amongst young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar. A quantitative survey will be used via an anonymous online questionnaire to measure the level of sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors. The obtained data will be analyzed using descriptive statistics as well as Spearman's rank-order correlation test. Such findings may aid in identifying gaps in sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors and support improvements in sexual health education in Myanmar.

Introduction

Sexually Transmitted Infections are infections that spread mainly through sexual contact, including vaginal, anal, or oral sex. STIs can be caused by various bacteria, viruses, and parasites [1]. The most common STIs include chlamydia, gonorrhea, syphilis, trichomoniasis, and genital herpes [2]. Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV) is also an important sexually transmissible infection. Although HIV can spread via other routes involving infected bodily fluids [3], it primarily spreads from sexual contact [4].

STIs are a major public-health concern, with more than 1 million curable sexually transmissible infections acquired worldwide every day among individuals aged 15-49, with most cases showing no symptoms, allowing infections to spread inadvertently [1].

Young people are particularly vital in STI prevention as accurate sexual health knowledge may aid them in understanding the risks and enable them to make decisions to adopt protective behaviors. However, research in Myanmar has identified gaps in this knowledge. According to a UNESCO report, it is observed that only 16.67% of young adults in Myanmar aged 15-24 possess accurate knowledge about the prevention of the spread of HIV [5].

Previous studies have examined sexual health knowledge and sexual behaviors amongst young people in Myanmar; however, there is relatively little research that investigates the relationship between sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors. Hence, this study aims to investigate the extent to which sexual health knowledge is associated with STI prevention behaviors among young people in Myanmar.

Research Questions

This study primarily aims to investigate the extent to which sexual health knowledge is associated with STI prevention behaviors among young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar. The question is clear and relevant as it aims to examine if differences in levels of sexual health knowledge are related to differences in STI prevention behaviors. This study will specifically answer the following questions:

1. What is the level of sexual health knowledge amongst young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar?
2. What STI prevention behaviors are practiced by young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar?

3. Is there a statistically significant association between the level of sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors among young people aged 15–24 in Myanmar?

Hypothesis

- Null Hypothesis
  There is no significant association between the level of sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors amongst young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar.

- Alternative Hypothesis
  There is a significant association between the level of sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors amongst young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar.

Literature Review

According to the World Health Organization, sexual health is defined as "a state of physical, emotional, mental, and social well-being connected to sexuality" [6]. Sexual health education plays a major role in helping young people understand sexually transmissible infections, their methods of transmission, and how to prevent them. On the other hand, studies suggest that gaps remain in sexual and reproductive knowledge amongst young people in Myanmar.

For instance, a study conducted amongst students, teachers and parents in public high schools in Pyin Oo Lwin suggests that reproductive health knowledge was relatively low, with over half of the students saying that they were not receiving any form of sex education at school [7]. Similarly, in another study conducted amongst University Students in Magway Division, half of the total number of students demonstrated inadequate sexual and reproductive health literacy [8]. Such findings suggest that limited access to accurate sexual health information still poses an issue amongst young people in Myanmar.

In another study, knowledge regarding HIV was tested in 2015-16 amongst youth in Myanmar. Out of the 4645 young people questioned, 38.3% had high knowledge, 32% had moderate knowledge, and 29.7% had low knowledge. Furthermore, only 20.4% of youths had heard of other STIs [9]. Such findings suggest that there are gaps in HIV and STI knowledge amongst young people in Myanmar.

Previously conducted studies from 2008 have also investigated sexual-risk and prevention behaviors among young people in Myanmar. In a study involving 210 young people aged 15–24, Pacheun et al. found that only 15.9% of participants with previous sexual experience reported always using condoms, while 27% reported having more than one sexual partner. Moreover, the study found that age, marital status, occupation, monthly income, and level of knowledge were significantly associated with levels of HIV/AIDS risk behavior [10].

Overall, previous research has examined sexual health knowledge, reproductive-health literacy, and sexual risk behaviors in Myanmar. However, the studies identified above

show that there is still little research specifically on the association between sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors amongst young people in Myanmar. Hence, this study aims to address this gap and identify the association between the two variables.

Methodology

This study will use a quantitative approach, using a quantitative survey to identify the extent to which sexual health knowledge is associated with STI prevention behaviors among young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar.

Variables

- Independent Variable: Level of sexual health knowledge
- Dependent Variable: STI prevention behaviors

Study Design

The study will be conducted using an anonymous online questionnaire to measure the level of sexual health knowledge as well as STI prevention behaviors. The questionnaire will consist of two sections: the first for sexual health knowledge and the second for STI prevention behaviors, with both sections composed of 50 questions (total 100 questions).

The 1st Section of the questionnaire will consist of knowledge-based questions. Each correct answer will be awarded 1 point, and each incorrect or "unsure" answer will be awarded 0 points. The total score of the participants will represent their level of sexual health knowledge.

For the 2nd Section of the questionnaire, STI prevention behaviors will be measured via questions about different prevention practices such as condom use, STI testing, and other preventive behaviors. Each response will be awarded 0-2 points, where 0 represents "never practiced," 1 represents "occasionally practiced," 2 represents "consistently practiced," and "non-applicable," where the data is excluded from the calculation. The greater the total score, the greater the extent of participation in STI prevention practices.

Data Collection

Participants aged 15-24 in Myanmar will be recruited via quota sampling using an anonymous online questionnaire. Data collection will be conducted across different areas of Myanmar with a target sample size of 400 participants. A target of 400 participants was selected to provide a large dataset for statistical analysis whilst remaining within the time frame of the study. Furthermore, participants from different areas of Myanmar will be recruited to increase geographic diversity.

Data Analysis

The collected data will be summarized using descriptive statistics as well as Spearman's rank-order correlation test to determine associations between sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors.

Ethical Concerns

29 Before taking part in the study, participants will be informed about the study and its purpose, and consent will be obtained. Furthermore, participation will be voluntary, and participants may stop taking part in the study at any given time.

4 Additionally, participants between the ages of 15 and 17 will be required to obtain parental or guardian consent. Responses will be kept confidential, and results will be reported without identifying participants.

Timeline

- *Week 1-2:* Choose and finalize the research question, the questionnaire, as well as relevant references concerning the topic
- *Week 3-5*: Distribute the questionnaire and collect the data
- 24 *Week 6*: Organize and check data
- *Week 7*: Conduct statistical analysis and interpret findings
- *Week 8*: Review the findings, complete the final report, and present the findings

Conclusion:

27 In conclusion, this study aims to research the association between sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors among young people aged 15-24 in Myanmar. 6 Previous research has suggested that gaps in sexual health knowledge and prevention behaviors are still present amongst young people; however, there is limited research 6 investigating the relationship between the two variables. By measuring the level of sexual health knowledge and STI prevention behaviors, this study aims to provide further evidence regarding this issue amongst young people in Myanmar.

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